

The AI Readiness Checklist

12 quick checks before you spend a penny on AI tools

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- [] Write down the 3 tasks that eat the most time each week - AI is only worth it if it removes real hours.
- [] Check whether the tool ever sends your data to train someone else's model (read the privacy page, not the marketing page).
- [] Confirm the tool has a UK/EU data option or a clear GDPR position before any customer data goes near it.
- [] Ask "what happens if it is wrong?" for each task - low-stakes tasks (drafts, summaries) are safe first steps; anything customer-facing needs a human check.
- [] Set a monthly budget cap before you start - most useful tools cost under GBP 30/month per person.
- [] Pick ONE tool and ONE task to start with. Trying five tools at once is how AI projects stall.
- [] Give it two real weeks before judging it - the first few days are always slower while you learn the prompts that work.
- [] Write down the prompts that worked well - a shared "prompt library" saves the whole team relearning it.
- [] Tell your team what it's for (and what it isn't for) - unclear AI policies cause more problems than the tools themselves.
- [] Review after 90 days: did it save the time you hoped? If not, stop paying for it - no shame in that.

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